

China: CPI and PPI surprises may indicate further reflation

- *CPI inflation rose at a stronger-than-expected rate (0.2%*m/m* sa), on faster increases in energy and services prices.*
- *PPI accelerated at a rate of 1.8%*m/m* sa (2.8%*oya*), consolidating gains in March, driven by imported inflation in energy-related products and travel-related domestic demand.*
- *Producer goods PPI accelerated to 3.8%*oya*, while the consumer goods PPI decline further narrowed by 0.3 ppt to -1.0%.*
- *With energy prices remaining elevated and signs of a demand patch-up, we revise up our full-year CPI and PPI inflation forecasts to 1.1%*y/y* (from 1.0%) and 2.5%*y/y* (from 1.3%), albeit with continued domestic weaknesses.*
- *We expect the energy price pass-through to CPI inflation to slowly pick up and the anti-involution campaign to show effects, with CPI edging closer to the 2% target.*

April inflation readings surprised on the upside, with CPI and PPI inflation rising at higher-than-expected 1.2%*oya* and 2.8%, respectively. Upward momentum is building, driven by imported inflation in energy and energy-related products (petro, gas, coal, chemicals), as well as travel services related to Qingming holiday, Labor Day holiday and spring breaks in some areas. Some of these seasonal effects will continue into May. Consumer goods PPI deflation further narrowed to -1.0%*oya* following a trend that started in January.

Headline CPI inflation rose to 1.2%*oya* from March's 1.0% (J.P. Morgan and Bloombergconsensus: 0.9%), on a 0.2%*m/m* sa uptick. The rise in energy prices partly reflects the ongoing closure of the Strait of Hormuz, despite a tenuous truce in the Middle East conflict. According to the NBS, gasoline prices accelerated to 19.3%*oya*, despite the government's price controls and smoothing measures, lifting CPI inflation by about 0.56 ppt. The prices of household appliances and clothing rose by 2.6% and 1.6%, respectively, together contributing 0.11 ppt. Adding to this is a significant increase in travel demand, driven by spending related to the Qingming Festival, the Labor Day holiday, and spring breaks in some areas: travel service prices rose 3.7%, driving up CPI inflation by 0.13 ppt, on seasonality that should persist into May. Prices for medical and educational services rose by 3.4% and 0.5%, respectively, together contributing about 0.25 ppt. The main drag came from food prices (-1.6%*oya* vs 0.3% Mar), especially a pork price decline (-15.2%) that drove down inflation by 0.29 ppt. Excluding food and energy, core CPI rose 1.2%*oya* (0.1%*m/m* sa).

PPI inflation rose sharply to 1.8%*m/m* sa (2.8%*oya* vs. J.P. Morgan: 1.4%; consensus: 1.8%), strengthening the momentum shift recorded in March. The main driver remained the continued rise in imported inflation in energy and energy-related goods, led by oil and gas extraction (18.5%*m/m* nsa), petroleum/coal and other fuel processing (16.4%), and chemicals (8.3%). Rising domestic demand in some sectors played a role, e.g., demand for computing power and electrification led fiber optic manufacturing prices to rise by 22.5%*m/m* nsa, and the prices of external storage equipment and components by 3.2%. The anti-involution campaign has apparently led to a more orderly market competition, narrowing price declines in related

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industries: lithium-ion battery manufacturing prices rose by 1.6%, while NEV manufacturing prices fell by 0.1% (-0.8% Mar). Producer goods PPI accelerated to 3.8%oya (2.2%m/m sa), while consumer goods PPI deflation narrowed to -1.0%oya (0.02%m/m sa), despite weak pass-through from upstream to downstream prices.

Even as the ceasefire, agreed on April 8 between the United States and Iran, has remained in force, the Strait of Hormuz continues to be practically closed, keeping global energy prices at elevated levels and squeezing the supply of downstream usable fuels. China is feeling the pinch, more in prices. A peaceful resolution of the conflict and the subsequent reopening of the Strait of Hormuz could alleviate the pressure coming from the shortage of crude, natural gas and other related products, but the production, shipping and re-stocking may take time even as a peace agreement comes into effect. Much hope is deposited with the planned [Trump-Xi summit](#) in Beijing on May 14-15, with a US-Iran peace deal likely to be high on the agenda. Nevertheless, it is quite possible that no deal is forthcoming, or the subsequent implementation process suffers from further disruptions. A closed Strait of Hormuz would keep up the pressure on prices. While domestic demand remains weak, there are some signs of price recovery, the strength and sustainability of which remains to be seen.

Following strong upside surprises to PPI and CPI inflation, we revise upward our full-year PPI and CPI inflation forecasts to 2.5%/y (from 1.3%) and 1.1%/y (from 1.0%), respectively. Yet, given the still weak domestic demand, possible downside risks to exports, and existing oversupply in some sectors, China's PPI deflation pressure may persist and PPI deflation could re-emerge. Besides higher energy costs, pass-through to CPI remains limited with a time lag, so it may still take time for it to edge up closer to the NPC target of around 2%.

Consumer price indices

percent change

	2025	Jan-26	Feb-26	Mar-26	Apr-26
Headline CPI					
%oya	0.0	0.2	1.3	1.0	1.2
%m/m, sa		-0.6	0.7	0.2	0.2
Food CPI					
%oya	-1.4	-0.7	1.7	0.3	-1.6
%m/m, sa		-1.3	0.6	-0.6	-1.0
Non-food CPI					
%oya	0.4	0.4	1.3	1.2	1.8
%m/m, sa		-0.2	0.7	0.1	0.4
Core CPI					
%oya	0.8	0.8	1.8	1.1	1.2
%m/m, sa		-0.3	0.9	-0.4	0.1

Source: NBS; J.P. Morgan

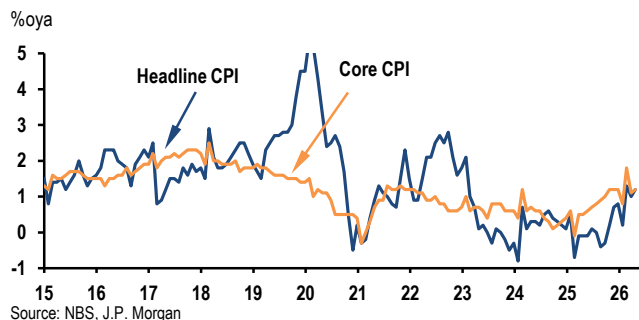
Producer prices

percent change

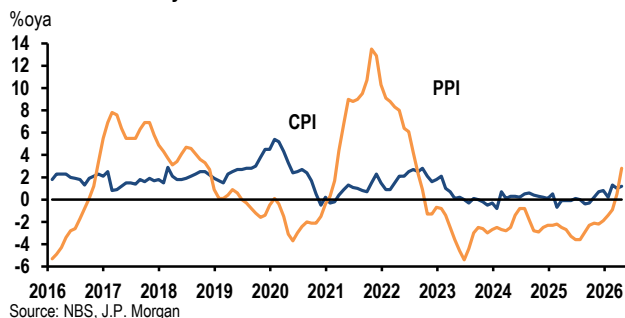
	2025	Jan-26	Feb-26	Mar-26	Apr-26
Producer (NBS)					
%oya	-2.6	-1.4	-0.9	0.5	2.8
%m/m, sa		0.3	0.4	0.9	1.8
Producer goods					
%oya	-3.0	-1.3	-0.7	1.0	3.8
%m/m, sa		0.5	0.5	1.1	2.2
Consumer goods					
%oya	-1.5	-1.7	-1.6	-1.3	-1.0
%m/m, sa		-0.2	0.0	0.0	0.0

Source: NBS; J.P. Morgan

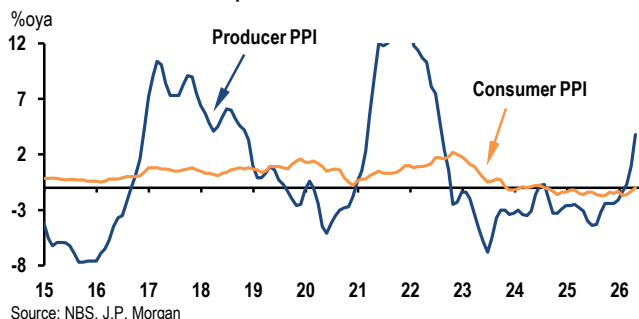
China: CPI trends



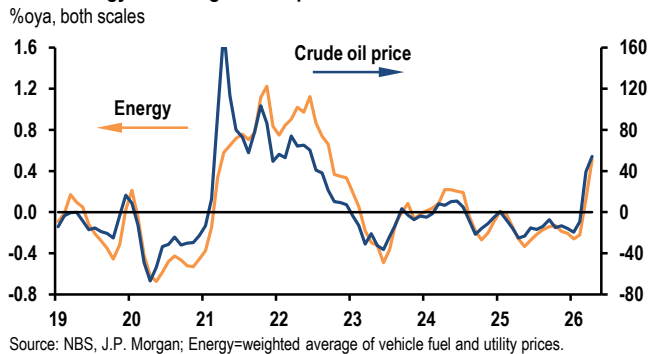
China's inflation dynamics



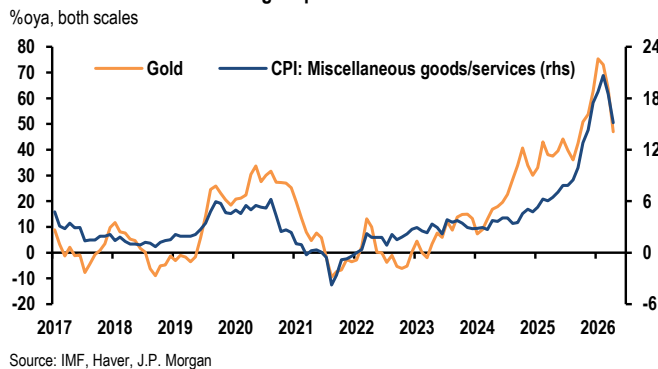
China PPI: consumer vs. producer



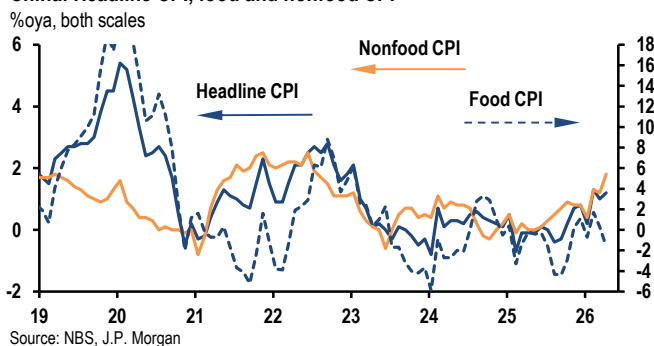
China energy CPI and global oil price



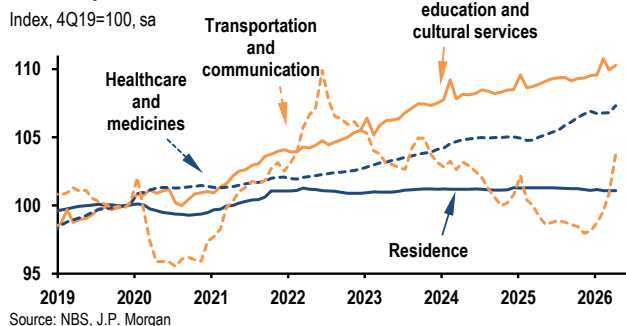
China: Miscellaneous CPI vs. gold prices



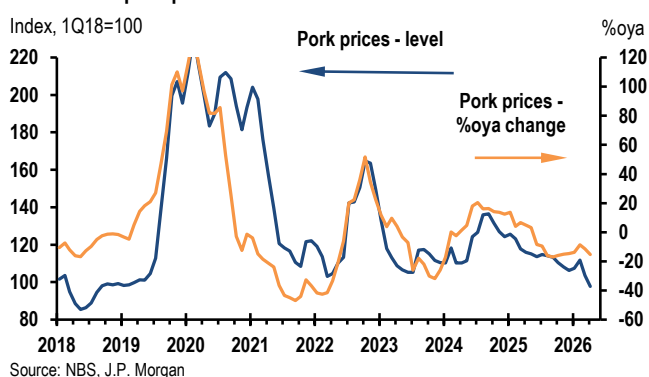
China: Headline CPI, food and nonfood CPI



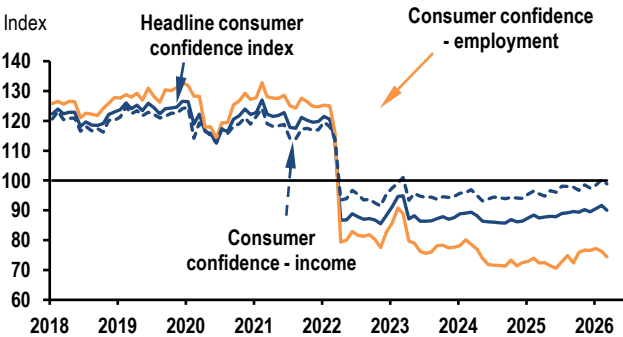
China: Major service-related CPI items



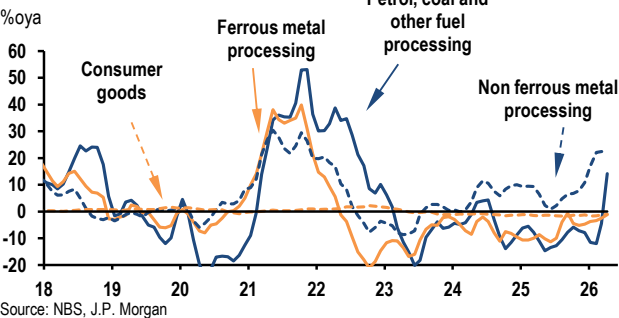
China: CPI - pork prices



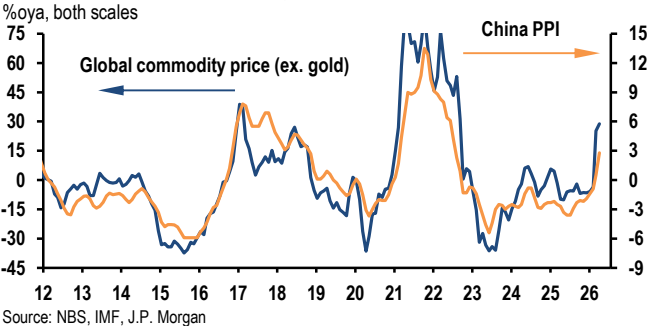
China consumer confidence index



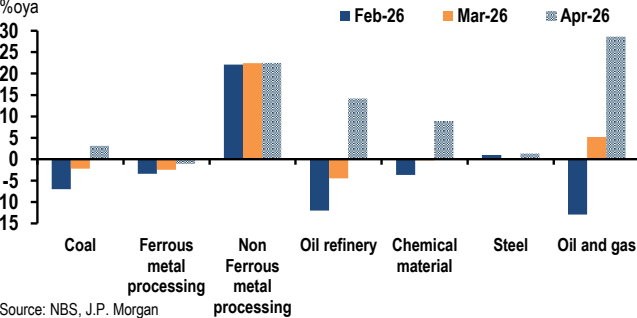
China PPI breakdown



China: PPI vs. global commodity price index



China PPI by industry



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